

Key to House held by handful of seats

Flurry of redistricting leaves a historically small number of ‘toss-up’ contests.

By Gregory Korte

A shrinking number of seats will determine control of the U.S. House after Republicans and Democrats spent much of the last year redrawing congressional maps to erase swing districts.

Even before Florida’s Legislature approved a new Republican-leaning map last week, just 16 seats were listed as “toss-ups” by the Cook Political Report, the nonpartisan newsletter that serves as an unofficial electoral scorekeeper. Another 16 districts are listed as leaning toward Democrats or Republicans, with the outcome all but predetermined for more than 400 seats.

This could make for the fewest competitive seats since political analyst Charlie Cook first published his race ratings in 1984. That means even if historical trends and current events favor Democrats heading into November, they’re likely to fall short of the 41 districts they picked up in the 2018 midterms during the first Trump administration.

“There aren’t really 40 seats on the board potentially right now just because of redistricting and that polarization,” said Carrie Dann, managing editor of the Cook Political Report.

That reality allows the two political parties to concentrate their resources. The Democratic House campaign operation lists 44 Republican districts in play, and the GOP equivalent is aiding 17 challengers hoping to unseat Democratic incumbents.

Those numbers can change after primary elections, but one Republican operative familiar with the party’s plans said the total number of contested seats is about half of what the parties fought over in the last midterm election in 2022.

Republicans say the smaller map favors them. Before the most recent spate of map changes, only three Republican House members were elected in districts

Democrats buck the establishment

Restless voters are rejecting party’s leadership and embracing new risks for midterms. **NATION, A9**

Weaker dollar is ‘a hidden tax’

Trend since Trump took office is good for multinationals but adds to consumers’ burden. **NATION, A8**

Resilient Lakers respect Thunder

“We know what kind of task we have in front of us,” coach JJ Redick says of defending champs. **SPORTS, D1**

Musical revivals alive and well

A trio of vibrant musicals on Broadway are showcasing the power of radical reinvention. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

A shower in spots. L.A. Basin: 69/55. **B5**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



PHOTOS of Iranians killed in the war, top, are displayed on Westwood Boulevard in Los Angeles. Above, a Persian grocery features flags of pre-revolution Iran.

Israel uses AI targeting system to track, kill foes

Troves of data give the military a sense of omniscience in attacks on Hezbollah figures.

By NABIH BULOS

BEIRUT — The buzz of the Israeli drone was constant that day, and every time Ahmad Turmus looked up, it seemed to be circling over him, like an all-too-patient bird of prey.

So when the phone rang as he was visiting family one Monday afternoon in February, Turmus wasn’t too sur-

prised that the person speaking accented Arabic was an Israeli military officer.

What surprised him was the question.

“Ahmad, you want to die with those around you or alone?”

Turmus, according to family members interviewed, answered with one word before hanging up: “Alone.”

The targeting of Turmus, which Israel acknowledged, demonstrates how, time and again, its military has mastered an intelligence war for which the militant group Hezbollah appears to have

no answer.

Ever since the spectacular pager attacks of September 2024 — when Israel remotely detonated explosives hidden in pagers carried by Hezbollah members — foot soldiers, support personnel, field commanders, chiefs of staff and even a revered secretary general have been felled by a targeting system powered by artificial intelligence.

The system, which fuses data from smartphones, security and traffic cameras, Wi-Fi signals, drones, government databases and social media, has granted Isra-

[See Israel, A4]



LEONILA and Juliana Preciado at their Mexican food spot in Norwalk.

Home restaurants, now legal, expand L.A. taste

By Itzel Luna

A radical deregulation of restaurant requirements is turning hundreds of backyards into booming businesses and reshaping how Los Angeles eats.

A state initiative to make it easier to start home food businesses has taken off in the last year. It is not only bringing more options to food deserts, but also empowering smaller, local entrepreneurs who were operating illegally, says Roya Bagheri, executive director of the Cook Alliance, the nonprofit behind the home restaurant law.

“People are already doing this,” but without licenses, she said. “This is

really an example of the government meeting the people and the community where they are.”

On any given weekend, a line snakes around the block for Carnitas El Bigoton Becerra, a Mexican food spot in Norwalk.

Customers spill into the street, drawn to the joint’s handmade tortillas, slow-cooked pork and aguas frescas, but it has no sign, parking lot or industrial kitchen.

The entire operation is run out of the family’s home.

Roberto Preciado Jr., his two siblings and their parents began selling food out of their home four years ago.

[See Backyard, A7]

Detentions sow division among L.A. Iranians

A vocal segment has joined forces with far-right activists in lobbying accusations.

By Suhauna Hussain

Sarina Hosseiny said she had never heard of Qassem Suleimani, an Iranian general assassinated by the U.S. in 2020.

That is, not until this year, when threatening comments cropped up on social media claiming that she and her mother were relatives of Suleimani and were terrorists who should be deported.

The 25-year-old, who studies fashion at Los Angeles Trade-Technical College, now sits in an immigration detention facility in Texas, alongside her 47-year-old mother. And other L.A. Iranian Americans helped put her there.

“They were sending me death threats. Literally saying like, they were gonna find me and kill me and my mom and all this stuff,” Hosseiny said in a phone interview from the facility last month. “All I’ve ever posted is that I

was against war and just innocent people dying.”

In recent weeks, as the war in Iran continues, the U.S. State Department has detained five L.A. area-based Iranian nationals, including Hosseiny and her mother — all of whom are green card holders — and moved to strip them of their residency.

The arrests have exposed a rift in the Iranian American community, which has grown increasingly polarized in recent years, leading to online smear campaigns and at times violence.

In L.A., home to the largest concentration of people of Iranian descent outside Iran, a vocal segment has joined forces with Trump-aligned far-right conservatives, including Laura Loomer, to wage campaigns against other Iranians they believe should not be allowed to live here.

Many in the local community fled Iran after the Islamic Revolution in 1979 and cheered the recent U.S. military attacks on their native country. Some have turned on Iranian Americans who have expressed antiwar

[See Iranians, A7]

IRAN WAR: Trump says U.S. will help “guide” stranded ships from the Strait of Hormuz. **WORLD, A2**

ICE raids still cast shadow over malls in Latino areas

By Roger Vincent and Itzel Luna

Close to a year after chilling immigration raids started across Los Angeles, the specter of ICE continues to depress business at many Southland shopping centers even when no immigration officers are in sight.

One mall landlord likened the effect to a mild replay of the COVID-19 pandemic emergency, as shoppers and mall employees cut back on time spent at malls in Latino neighborhoods.

Family shopping jaunts that were once leisurely affairs are being scrapped in favor of quick trips during off-hours to grab essentials and go home, suffering business owners say. Business is down for many merchants, and attendance has fallen at community events such as job fairs and holiday celebrations.

The potential for a surprise visit by U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents is still keeping people on edge, landlords say.

“They’re afraid there’s going to be a raid and who knows what happens,” mall operator Sandy Sigal said. “And even for those that are legal, I think the view is that they still get caught up in this, and why go through that?”

Sigal’s NewMark Merrill Cos. owns or manages more than 110 shopping centers in the U.S., including in Santa Ana, Inglewood and Thousand Oaks, that cater to millions of Latino shoppers.

“We’re still affected” by previous ICE raids, said Emad Dalati, owner of a UPS store at NewMark’s Bristol Warner Marketplace in Santa Ana. “A lot of customers I used to see in the past, I haven’t seen in a long time. They disappeared.”

ICE arrests have fallen in recent months, and the number of people in immigration detention has dropped from a high of roughly 72,000 in January to 58,000 last week, according to data obtained by the Associated Press.

But in a sign of its continued determination, ICE, in

[See Malls, A1f]

Recent quakes reveal Nevada’s hidden risk

By Rong-Gong Lin II

A recent series of earthquakes in Nevada has served as a jolting reminder of the state’s seismic risk.

It started with a scary earthquake near Reno, then more unsettling shaking near Las Vegas. Neither earthquake caused significant damage, but it has gotten Nevada talking about the large geological forces that caused them.

While California is known for its seismic activity, experts say, the danger does not stop at the state line. There are many fault systems that crisscross the California-Nevada border, and one area scientists worry about is the Lake Tahoe Basin, according to Christie

Rowe, director of the Nevada Seismological Laboratory.

“There are some big faults under the lake there. They’ve had pretty major earthquakes in the past,” she said.

The latest sizable quake in the Silver State struck at 1:17 a.m. Friday, a magnitude 5.2 about 40 miles east of Reno. Just two days earlier, a magnitude 4.4 rumbled in the desert about 60 miles north of Sin City, where some people reported weak shaking.

The area east of Reno also endured a flurry of seismic activity earlier in April. The most powerful of that series was a magnitude 5.7 earthquake 45 miles east of the city that was strong

[See Nevada, A8]